



Rusty's Report

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Please submit art!

The Tangos are back by popular (?) demand. This is a light newsletter this month - hope to be back strong next month!

-be_loved



Dungeon Master Tango



Regular Tango

Please submit art!

Valentine's Grove

by Marsmellow

Because we are nearing the end of the season and our staff and mods are behind the scenes, scrambling to get everything ready to take us to the next season, unfortunately this year there were no official Valentine's Day plans.

So, we decided to take matters into our own hands.

It was JoHoste who came up with the idea to do something Valentine-y for the server. The initial plan was to create a Valentine district. Build an island in the ocean next to spawn and make it "The Love Island" where people could build all the lovey-dovey builds they wanted. Now, because it was the evening of the 13th, literally 3 hours before Valentine's day, we decided to skip the building-a-big-ol'-island-from-scratch idea and thought of a more feasible plan.

Together with Zadhiya, who fortunately was online to help, we build a lovely green and very very pink oasis on the border of the entertainment district, just behind Tango's shirt. (It's a game in the ED people, get your minds out of the gutter! Geez!)



We called it "Valentine's Grove". Here, every Titan is invited to leave a little love note for another player that they like or everyone on the server if you like everyone the same.

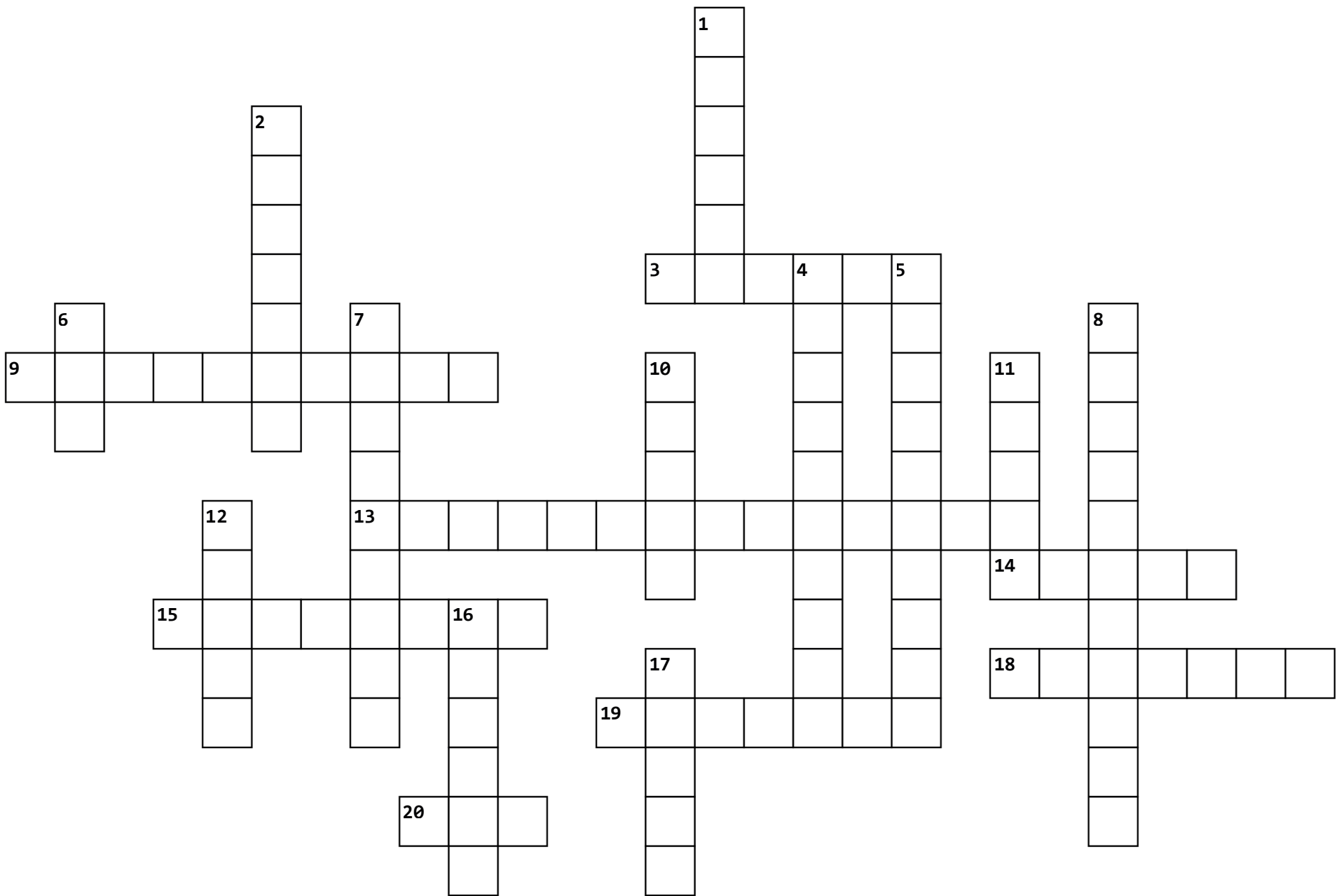
We know Valentine's Day is already over, but who is gonna stop us from spreading the love all year long? Or at least until the season ends..

That's right! Nobody! So come check out the signs that are already there, you might have a message waiting! And of course, don't be shy to leave your own messages.





Name that Titan



Across

- 3. She's the Best
- 9. Everyone gets Maps!
- 13. The Sand Queen
- 14. 800 Sheep
- 15. Server PokeGym Leader
- 18. Cat Statues and Controversy
- 19. Bunny Mom and World Class Helper
- 20. Mapped Marmalade

Down

- 1. Pink Buttons
- 2. Editor and Tango Fan Artist
- 4. Guitar or Fish
- 5. Most likely to Meow
- 6. Did someone say Dragon?
- 7. Needs 3072 different Fish
- 8. Hand holding Base
- 10. Terracotta of Ember
- 11. Sent to the Wall
- 12. Postal Frog
- 16. The Leaf Lady
- 17. Did someone say Minigame?

What It Takes to Prepare for a New Season of Titancraft

by ARocketEngineer

Alright folks. It's that time again. Time to prepare for another server reset.

What, you're not ready?

Why not?

It's been over a year at this point.

Surely, you've completed that mega project you started day one, right?

We did.

Cleanup your starting area to make it presentable?

Yup, good there.

Finish decorating the semi functional storage area?

There's still time.

Oh, and the redstone monstrosity, that's finished, right?

I don't want to talk about it, ok?



Anyways, back to the subject at hand: New World Prep. Like all new worlds in Minecraft, we need a good seed. For Titancraft, we need an amazing seed to match the amazing builds from our amazing community. Finding one is no small task. Several of the mods and staff scour the millions and billions of seeds, hunting for the right one. You know the kind. The right mix of biomes, lots of fun structures like witch huts and woodland mansions to build around. Oh, and a great big mushroom island or two.

Now, I'll let you in on a little secret: we don't all agree on which seed is best. Some folks want one big island. Others, several. Some want things spread out while others like it compact. So what do we do in those situations? Why we take a vote of course. Surprised? Well don't be, the staff and mods vote on a lot of things. Although we never seem to vote Caable out of the tribe for some odd reason...

Anyways, now that we have a seed chosen, the hard part starts. Designing spawn is a lot of work. Coming up with a theme, then a design, lots of revisions and reworks. Scaffolding everywhere, blocks falling on your head. Did you see the accident tracker in spawn this season? We never went more than a week before someone fell down a hole or got teleported to the nether by accident. It's always a mess.

While things above ground are under construction, other crews are hard at work underground. Do you have any idea how much junk is underground in a new seed? OMG. Caves and lush caves, trial chambers, geodes, spawners, abandoned mineshafts. Everything under the shopping district gets filled in. It takes days. So exhausting moving that much stone and dirt.

Then comes the plotting. You know, setting up the shop plots. First, the mushrooms must go. Big, small, red or brown, they all go. The mooshrooms are allowed to stay, they make good stew and steak. Only when the funky fungus is gone can the actual layout of the shops begin. Oh, what a thing of geometric beauty. All squares and grids. Straight lines as far as the render distance allows. And no, Yotta, I'm not using Voxxy to see the whole district at once. It crashes my laptop, ok? Deal with it. Let me have my wonderful pattern fading into the distance fog.

With the plots in, it's time for the road crew. Like all new roads, these start as just simple dirt paths. It's up to you, the community, to make them look nice. We will let you get geared up and do some material gathering before that happens, don't worry. Once the roads are in, the shopping district is ready but won't be open until a few days into the season. We gotta give shop keepers some time to gather the goods.

Once spawn has been mostly designed, the crew starts in on the more technical stuff. The resource world connections are prepped. The map art world is readied. Oh, and the fun bit: closing off the End! So much fun setting those traps, I mean building those early day end zones. It's not like we intentionally make it fatal with no way back or anything. We would never do a thing like that. I will say that while I had a hand in the mini end island from this season, Drop is still the evil genius to come up with that button room for Season 9. Maybe we should put that one in the Above somewhere. Just a thought.

Anyways, back to the story. So, spawn is built, shop plots are in, End is closed. What else is needed, you might ask? Pre-gen. That's right folks, despite what you might think, we pre-generate the world before you ever see it. All 900 million plus blocks of the Overworld. Nether and End too but those are easier. With that, the worlds are ready. But those need software to run on, and that's where things get a little crazy.

For all prior seasons of Titancraft, all the worlds were run on a single instance of Minecraft. Veterans can attest to lag issues, especially early on. Breaking blocks multiple times, not being able to eat, chunks not loading. Dogs and cats...whoops, sorry wrong story. Back on topic, Rocket.

Anyways, for Season 10, Titancraft decided to use a multiple-server setup for the first time. This is something that had been in discussion for YEARS. Finally, the moderators were able to get it functioning well enough for us to use. Was it easy? Absolutely. Not. Let's just say, as a knuckle dragging mechanical type, the level of cursing required to get it functional was impressive. And given it was the technological wizard we know as Terk who was doing the cursing, I'm not sure I want to know what magics or spells or sacrifices were involved.

And for Season 11 it's no better this time around because Mojang has changed things yet again. So, while we are fairly close to being ready, there's still backend stuff in alpha release. We've got a whole crew working on it this time. And given what they've done so far, I wouldn't be surprised if we can get it working soon(TM). What, you expected me to say something else? HA! I'm not that nice.

So now, we've got a seed, spawn and Shopping District prepped, world generated, servers servering. What else is left? Oh! Showing the Boss Man around! We've gotten pretty good at shuffling him from build to build over the years but he still runs around like a squirrel. We love him for that though so no big deal. Once the showcase is done, server closes and a few days later a new world begins.

And there you have it, what it takes to set up for a new season of Titancraft. For those who have been there on day one, you know what kind of chaos and fun it is. For those who have never joined in those early day experiences, we invite you to join us. Once its ready that is.

We interrupt your frantic season-end building for an important bulletin:

Capybara Onsen

by TaintedSorrow



At the Saitama Children's Zoo, just an hour north from Tokyo, capybaras wow Japanese visitors with their calm, easygoing demeanor, cute appearance...
...and love for hot baths.

Just like snow monkeys, capybaras across Japan enjoy hot onsen baths in winter. But today the zoo reached a balmy 70° F (21° C), unseasonably warm for February (considering that the Tokyo Haneda airport was literally snowed in barely two weeks ago!), so the capybaras had to be encouraged to enter the baths with treats and never lingered for more than a few minutes, stepping into the wading pool and rolling around to cool off.



In contrast, the annual Capybara Long Bath Showdown sees soaks for well over an hour!



The baths at the Saitama zoo are a toasty 98.6° F or 37° C, better suited to winter temperatures, and run from the beginning of December to mid-March. And it's not the only place in Japan to see capybaras soaking up to their nose – zoos across the country have created hot springs for them. Many also allow visitors to closely approach or even interact with the capybaras. Saitama has a foot bath for guests to soak along with the giant rats.

Given that capybaras are not native to Japan (they’re native to South America), you might be asking…

Why capybara?

The popularity of capybaras has surged across Japan! To the Japanese, the hooded, placid appearance of these giant rats embody the concept of iyashikei, which is used to describe a person or thing that imparts feelings of calm and healing. Japan is a notoriously over-worked country, and stress-relieving and health improving measures, however gimmicky or real, are insanely popular. Iyashikei is even a quality sought after in relationships.

Capybaras are also social animals, which echoes the Japanese lifestyle of group consensus and conformity. Especially when adding the capybara’s cute furry appearance to a culture that loves its cute mascots, these qualities make the capybara a well-known and adored animal. Every time a capybara entered the bath, the Japanese around me exclaimed, “Cute!” and “Wow!” even when seeing this activity multiple times.



Soo…

Why onsen?

Capybaras are naturally water-loving animals. Apparently the trend of capybaras soaking in onsens dates back to the 1980s at Izu Shaboten Zoo, where capybaras enjoyed soaking in the hot water that was used to clean their enclosure. Those hot puddles were eventually upgraded to onsen baths, and the craze caught on around Japan. Each zoo is different, and at Saitama Zoo, the capybaras particularly like sitting under the cascading water feature.



There is now a yearly ‘Capybara Long Bath Showdown’ to see which capybara in Japan can soak the longest. This year’s winner was Prune from Nagasaki Bio Park (rivals with Hechima from Saitama Children’s Zoo, who holds the title of Watermelon Queen for four consecutive wins at the annual speed-eating contest), with a time of 1 hour, 45 minutes, and 18 seconds.

You might have seen images of capybara bathing with yellow-orange fruit called yuzu.

Why yuzu?

Yuzu is a citrus fruit that ripens in winter, and is seen as a sign of good luck. It is a source of vitamin C and good for skincare, so it is traditionally added to special baths in winter, helping to reduce stress. When capybara started partaking in onsen bathing, the fruit is often added as well. (It’s just very cute.) It releases a pleasant aroma in the hot water that is also nice for the visitors. Unfortunately, no fruit was added to the baths today. A scientific study found that hot spring bathing improved capybaras’ skin from the dry, rough skin that developed in winter to its state from the summer. It also showed that these baths increased the capybaras’ comfort level.

But capybara onsen aren’t the only capybara feature in Japan!

There are also capybara cafes!

To be continued…

